

– The Classical –

Alienation

Karl Marx



The Idea

HAVE YOU EVER FELT 'ALIEN' OR 'ALIENATED'? HAVE YOU EVER FELT THAT EVERYONE IS against you, that you are a stranger in your own home, a foreigner in your own land, that no-one understands you and that you feel isolated, rejected and divorced from the people around you, whether they be your parents, your family, your friends, or just the people in your local community or town? You feel that you no longer belong and you feel a deep and profound sense of anger and frustration. Pretty strong feelings, no doubt, that on the one hand make you feel inadequate, inferior and unwanted; and on the other hand make you feel passionately angry, resentful and determined to prove people wrong and to re-establish your rightful place in your group, society or community. Such feelings, such passions inspire either fatalism, an acceptance of alienation, of inferiority and of being displaced, 'homeless' even; or a fervent, passionate, even radical determination to change the situation, to change the world and make it more friendly, humane and inviting.

From a sociological and political point of view you can see in these words, the seeds of a radical, even revolutionary theory of how the world is – because people just accept it – and one of how the world could be if people were inspired to rise up and seek to change it, to make it a more human, friendly and just place. This indeed was the inspiration for Karl Marx as a young radical living in a period of immense and intense change, the Age of Revolution that swept across Europe in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries:

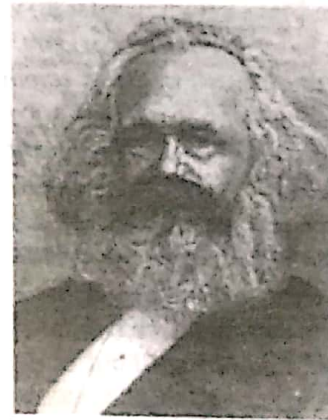
- the political revolutions in America, France and Europe;
- the economic revolutions that transformed Western societies from rural and agrarian communities to urban and industrial powerhouses;
- the scientific and intellectual revolution that not only inspired completely new ideas about the universe and about nature but also led to the development of modern science and the revolutionary ideas of the Enlightenment about the rights of man and the nature of society;

- the nationalist movements that swept across Europe and led to the unification of Germany, Italy and many other principalities and territories.

The range and depth of social change during this time was enormous and quite awesome. No-one seemed to be in control and so inevitably for most ordinary people there was an intense, uncontrollable feeling of helplessness, of being displaced, of being swept away by forces beyond their control, away from the homes and rural communities they belonged to, into the new and frightening world of the industrial factory and the urban city. How could all this change be explained? How could it be brought under control, and how could it be made less alienating, more welcoming, more humane?

Explaining this avalanche, this tidal wave of change, was the task that the young Karl Marx set himself in developing his initial ideas about capitalism and the capitalist revolution; changing this world for a better one, for a communist one, was the task that the older, more mature Marx set about in his later, more theoretical and scientific analyses and his call for a communist revolution.

As a Jew, born and brought up in Germany, Marx himself felt alienated, something of an alien or foreigner in his own country. As a radical writer and revolutionary activist forced to flee from Germany and then Paris, living in poverty with his family in London, he made himself homeless and an alien, unwanted in his homeland in the Rhineland and feared throughout Western Europe for his revolutionary activities. The 'Red Doctor' was refused citizenship even at one time by the British government and died in London in 1853. He may have died alone and in poverty, but as his colleague Friedrich Engels predicted at his graveside, 'His name will endure through the ages and so will his work'. Born in an age of revolution,



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Marx's ideas swept across Europe in the late nineteenth century and dominated the political history of the twentieth century. They inspired the communist revolutions in Russia and Eastern Europe, China and Asia, Africa and South America, and laid the basis for the communist-capitalist confrontations of the Cold War that followed World War II. No writer has inspired such radical change, no writer has inspired such passion and hatred, no writer has influenced the history of modern man as greatly as Karl Marx.

Karl Marx's key work, *Das Kapital* (1970), was a 'scientific' study of capitalism as an economic system and mode of production. His study of alienation was in contrast a study of the social, psychological and personal effects of capitalism on people's feelings and self-image. For Marx, capitalism is not only an unjust and inefficient system of economic production, it is an immoral and exploitative one, one that denies man his true nature, separates him from the products of his own labour and sets man against man in an economic 'jungle'. For Marx the essence of human nature, what distinguishes man from the animals, is his consciousness, his imagination, his ability to control his own environment. This power is most clearly expressed in the productive process where, by working together, men transform nature – felling trees to make houses, clearing forests to make roads. However, whenever this form of self-expression and social co-operation is in any way limited or thwarted, then alienation will occur.

In the *Paris Manuscripts* of 1844 (quoted in Bottomore and Rubel 1961) Marx outlined four key forms of alienation:

- When the worker has lost control of the end product. What he has produced, be it a table or chair, is no longer his but owned by his employer.
- When, through the extensive division of labour in modern factories, the worker no longer feels involved in the production process. He is merely 'a cog in the wheel', motivated not by the intrinsic satisfaction of work but only by the extrinsic one of the wage at the end of the week.
- When relationships between workers are not those of colleagues but of rivals, competitors for jobs, bonuses and promotion; and those between employer and worker are not the relationships of equals but of master and slave, as employers seek to maximise the profits from their workforce.
- Whenever the individual is denied the true essence of his human nature – self-expression through work. His work no longer feels part of him, nor represents his true talents. It is no longer a source of pride and achievement.

In Marx's own words: *'In what does this alienation of labour consist? First, that the work is external to the worker, that it is not a part of his nature, that consequently he does not fulfil himself in his work but denies himself, has a feeling of misery, not of well-being, does not develop freely a physical and mental energy, but is physically exhausted and mentally debased. The worker therefore feels himself at home only during his leisure, whereas at work he feels himself homeless. His work is not voluntary but imposed, forced labour. It is not the satisfaction of a need, but only a means for satisfying other needs. Its alien character is clearly shown by the fact that as soon as there is no physical or other compulsion it is avoided like the plague. Finally, the alienated character of work for the worker appears in the fact that it is not his work but for someone else, that in work he does not belong to himself but to another person'* (Bottomore and Rubel 1961).

Workers are therefore alienated from their work, from the products of their labour, from other workers and ultimately from their true selves. As Friedrich Engels argued, *'Nothing is more terrible than being constrained to do alone one thing every day from morning to night against one's will'* (quoted in Ritzer 1996: 59). Work becomes torture and so men turn elsewhere for release and a sense of control. They turn to drink and depression or to consumerism and a privatised lifestyle.

Although in Marx's analysis of history all previous economic systems involved a class structure and exploitative relationships and so generated a sense of alienation, capitalism does so more markedly – not only because exploitation is at its highest in such societies but because its 'market forces' lead to men being treated not as individuals but merely as another commodity of production to be used or discarded as the need arises. Only in a classless society, where the means of production are communally owned, will, Marx predicted, alienation be eliminated forever. Amid the abundance of modern mass production, 'communist' man would no longer work simply to survive, no longer specialise in one form of production or career but be free to express all his talents all of the time – to fish in the morning, hunt in the afternoon and criticise in the evening. All social divisions be they gender, or of race, town or country, brain or brawn, will, he predicted, disappear amid a society of equal individuals and communal care.

While man creates the social world through his own activity, the capitalist world is a world that people experience as alien and oppressive, a world in which relationships

are experienced not personally but as things. '*Political economy does not deal with the proletarian as a human being but "as a draught horse, as a beast whose needs are strictly limited to bodily needs"*' (Marx 1963). Although for Marx the proletariat is the most alienated social class in capitalist society, in his view even capitalists in their search for profit inhabit an alienated world. Even among the rich and wealthy, work and relationships are dehumanised and instead of work being an expression of human creativity, it is a denial of man's potential and an obstacle to building a truly human community. Man and his work in capitalist societies are fragmented by the division of labour and the division of ownership. Capitalist society is by definition built on alienated labour as the capitalist seeks to exploit the working class, extracting the surplus value of work from the proletariat as profit and as capital. Workers are alienated from the very fruits of their own labour. Work is no longer a means in itself but simply a means to survival.

In his later writings, Marx developed a more deterministic approach which portrayed man in a more passive mode. In *Gründrisse* (1973), for example, Marx wrote that '*social wealth confronts labour in more powerful proportions as an alien and dominant power . . . a monstrous objective power which created through social labour belongs not to the worker but . . . to capital*'. As capital accumulation grows, so labour becomes an ever-cheaper commodity, devalued and dehumanised – despite the appearance of men freely entering contractual agreements. So, argues Swinglewood (2000), alienation does not disappear from Marx's later works such as *Gründrisse*; it changes expression and becomes a more theoretical concept.

In Marx's view, therefore, while human history has seen a progressive increase in man's control over nature, this has been paralleled ironically by a corresponding increase in alienation, particularly in capitalist societies. People no longer recognise themselves in their own work, in their own society. They feel strangers at work, isolated and powerless in society and frustrated with having no outlet for their talents and ambitions. The world around them – even the products of their own work – becomes objectified. They feel powerless against the impersonal forces at work and in society at large and the products they produce are commodities to be sold at a price in the market place, not an expression of their own skills and creativity. Workers are prisoners of market forces over which they have no control. They have to sell their labour to survive and they have no control over supply, demand or price. In Marx's view, however, market forces are not natural or external forces with a life of their own; rather they are controlled by the capitalist class, by big business and the global corporations who own the means of production and seek to exploit labour as the primary means of capital accumulation and profit.

For Marx the result of wage labour and alienation is that man is degraded, dehumanised and 'no longer feels himself to be anything but an animal'. What distinguishes man from animals, work and the free conscious act of creativity disappears, and so man loses his 'species being', his distinct human qualities. Moreover the isolation and alienation of wage labour equally alienates men and women from each other and so destroys man's social being too, his sense of community and well-being as the distress and poverty of capitalist working life drives man into isolation and loneliness.

Thus, argued Marx, capitalism is an inverted world with those with the least talent at the top exploiting and living off the labours of others. Such power and control is hidden behind the illusion of market forces. It was Marx's aim to reveal such distortion and to set out a programme by which man might emancipate himself from the slavery

of capitalist society and be reunited as a full human being – free, dignified and fulfilled within an egalitarian and co-operative communist community.

Marx believed passionately in the power and potential of human beings. This belief was his primary motivation for analysing why man is so unfulfilled in present day capitalist society and how communist or classless society would free man, his spirit and his talents. Man differs from animals essentially in his consciousness and in particular, his self-consciousness, which arises from human action and interaction in a social context. What specifically distinguishes man from animals is his ability to consciously control, plan and pace his activity, his creative intelligence. Each historical epoch encourages or restricts such creative potential and class societies in particular suppress talent, consciousness and motivation. In comparing primitive society to capitalism, Marx argued that *'The ancients provide a narrow satisfaction whereas the modern world leaves us unsatisfied, or where it appears to be satisfied with itself, it is vulgar and mean'* (Ritzer 1996: 53). Capitalism has unleashed man's ability to produce unparalleled abundance in terms of material goods but it will take communism to bring out man's full talents and ambitions, his 'species power' as a distinct and unique human being in both work and leisure.

Marx equally believed in man's inherent sociability; *'Man is in the most literal sense of the word a "zoon politikon", not only a social animal but an animal which can develop into an individual only in society'* (Ritzer 1996: 55).

While class-based societies like capitalism distort man's consciousness and exploit and suppress his talents in the interests of profits and privilege, classless societies will free man as a fully conscious and highly co-operative productive being in the truest sense of the word.

For Marx, not only does the capitalist mode of production turn people's work, the fruits of their labour into a thing, a commodity, an object outside of their control, but it generates a 'fetishism of commodities', an obsession with owning things and with 'reification', the belief that society is a thing above and beyond the individual over which man has no control. Such reification may begin in the workplace and the market place with the apparently all embracing and impersonal power of the modern organisation and the vast powers of market forces, but it can be equally applied to our view of religion and the modern state. All property, and in particular the means of production, are privately owned. 'Private property is thus the product of alienated labour'.